

Artificial intelligence is the need of the hour to create safer roads in India

India has the unique distinction of being the fastest growing economy amongst the G-20 nations. Yet the country also has the dubious distinction of accounting for 11% of global deaths from road accidents despite having only 1% of the world's vehicles, according to the World Bank report. Weak enforcement of traffic laws, bad driving behaviour etc. are just the tip of the iceberg.

Business Today delved deeper into the matter with experts in the field, discussing technology that has revolutionised road safety in India through Artificial Intelligence (AI), Machine Learning (ML), and vision-based technologies. Speaking to Business Today on the matter are, Durgadutt Nedungadi, Vice President - India & International Business, Netradyne; Dr Rohit Baluja, President - Institute of Road Traffic Education; and Ramesh Agarwal, Chairman - All India Transport Welfare Association.



■ **Durgadutt Nedungadi**
Vice President - India & International Business, Netradyne



■ **Dr Rohit Baluja**
President - Institute of Road Traffic Education



■ **Ramesh Agarwal**
Chairman - All India Transport Welfare Association

According to the India Ministry of Road Transport and Highways, road crashes kill about 80,000 people every year. This startling statistic accounts for about 13% of the total fatality all over the world. How can vision-based technology really help in resolving this concern and bringing that number down? To what extent can this technology help in preventing some of these accidents?

Durgadutt Nedungadi: Netradyne was set up as a company with the mission to bring down accidents, save lives, save cargo, and so on. Accidents are a huge part of the problem. If you look at what causes

accidents, unfortunately, it is because of driver error. So, our aim, using vision-based technologies, is to pre-emptively alert the driver on many factors. It could be on how close his vehicle is to another vehicle in front of him in time, to avoid a collision; or it could pertain to the driver's behaviour themselves. In advanced countries where road signs, traffic lights, etc. all of those are consistent, we've found that the use of our device brings down the accident rates by as much as 40%. That's a huge number when you look at the number of lives that might be saved.

How does India stack up vis-à-vis developed nations in the adoption of safe driving

technology? What is the prevalent culture for technology adoption from a regulatory standpoint? How much have we progressed?

Dr Rohit Baluja: There is a fortunate and an unfortunate way that we are looking at technology. We are trying to leapfrog from a developing country to a developed country and whatever the latter is doing today, we just want to bring everything here and use it. Now, for example, the WHO says that there are 3,00,000 people dying on our roads every year, which is 820 every day. One fact is that 74% of our country's vehicles make up of two-wheelers and the number of people who die is 40% on two-